

The day after tomorrow for MySQL

MySQL is one product that almost everyone is talking about because it seems to compete with Oracle's database business. MySQL is arguably the most widely-used database for Web development and Web apps, and therefore has kept a sizable chunk of the market away from Oracle. This means, the acquisition could either spell the slow death of the open source database or fill its lungs with fresh air.

No doubt it's been anything but a bed of roses for MySQL after being

earlier acquired by Sun. Most of the key developers, including MySQL founders David Axmark and Michael "Monty" Widenius, left. Tiemann has the same view, "A year after Sun's acquisition of MySQL, the founders, CEO, and several lead developers had all left without any good things to say about Sun. To me, this hurt the otherwise stellar brand of MySQL. Fortunately, the open source community has many fine open source database projects, and whatever damage may have been done to the MySQL brand, an equal amount of good came to the other projects. Thus, there was no

net loss to the open source community, though there was a competitive shift among the various projects."

Monty came out with a new project and is currently working on Maria DB. However, he has no doubt about the quality of MySQL, and even has a few words of praise for Sun. He also says that Maria DB is less of a fork and more of a branch. He says that the core competency of MySQL is "...the people [behind it]! Sun has excellent support, sales and training people in the MySQL area. In the development part, they used to have excellent developers but a large

'Sun's failure is not the

...according to Michael Tiemann. Well, Tiemann is currently the president of the Open Source Initiative. However, his comments in this story and the following interview are his own opinion and does not represent that of the OSI's.

Q What is the general sentiment within the open source community post this acquisition?

I cannot speak for the whole community, but I offer the following thoughts:

1. A year after Sun's acquisition of MySQL, the founders, CEO, and several lead developers had all left without any good things to say about Sun. To me, this hurt the otherwise stellar brand of MySQL. Fortunately, the open source community has many fine open source database projects, and whatever damage may have been done to the MySQL brand, an equal amount of good came to the other projects. Thus, there was no net loss to the open source community, though there was a competitive shift among the various projects.
2. Sun's ambivalence in bringing Solaris and Java put Sun in a position of constantly explaining and apologising, rather than leading and innovating. Whatever advantages Solaris may have offered compared with Linux back in 2000 or 2001, today the Linux community is where the action is, not OpenSolaris. As for Java, Sun's attempt to 'protect' Java by keeping it proprietary has given a lot of ground to Microsoft, which really knows how to play the proprietary game. Had Sun been more willing to embrace open source principles earlier with Java, the whole competitive landscape might have been different.
3. Given that Sun itself made so many mis-steps with respect to its own open source execution, Oracle has its work cut out. Somehow, it has to do better than Sun with Sun's own assets, and this means both on the community side (where Sun failed) and on the

commercial side (where Sun was failing). Anything is possible, but some things are very difficult.

Q There are concerns about the future of some of the critical open source technologies now owned by Oracle. What do you see as the future of OpenOffice.org, Java, MySQL and OpenSolaris?

The great thing about open source is that the software can succeed and survive independent of any particular vendor. I believe that those projects with strong community support will continue to thrive. As for others that depended tremendously on Sun's own resources, it will be up to Oracle to continue that or not. And on the third hand, perhaps the community will decide independently to suddenly take interest in a project that it had previously ignored, if only because it now sees an opportunity to ride that project to successful independence.

Q Oracle is a hard-core enterprise-only, profit-driven company. Where does open source fit in its strategy?

By my estimation (see <http://opensource.org/node/384> and <http://tiny.cc/mt>), the proprietary software model is destroying US\$1 trillion of capital investment every year, because so many applications are abandoned before ever reaching production, and those that do make it to production are often so late, so broken, or both, that as much as 20 per cent of most other projects must also be written down. By contrast, I believe that open source is the best strategy for the enterprise. So in that case, I believe that open source